thing.’27 The following morning, Honecker was not lacking in self-confidence during a three-hour conversation with Gorbachev when he balked at the idea of reforms and treated the Soviet leader to a recap of his achievements. Containing his dismay, Gorbachev later claimed his ‘cautious attempts’ to convince the SED leader to make reforms led to no practical results whatever: ‘It was as if I had been speaking to a brick wall.’ Over in Moscow, Anatoly Chernyaev, a principal foreign-policy advisor to Gorbachev, unloaded details of the growing spat into his diary on 11 October:

I have read the record of conversation of M.S. [Gorbachev] with Honecker in Berlin. I spoke with him [Gorbachev] about this. [Georgy] Shakhnazarov was present. M.S. [Gorbachev] called Honecker an ‘asshole’ [mudak]. He, Gorbachev added, could have said to his [East German] lieutenants: I have undergone four operations, I am 78 years old, the stormy time requires too much strength, let me go, I have done my job. Then he might have kept his place in history.

Shakh [nazarov] and I voiced our doubts that even if he had done so he would have kept his place in history. Two or three years ago, it might have been possible. Today he has already been cursed by his people … The Politburo [of the SED] is in session for the second day in Berlin. [Honecker’s future successor Egon] Krenz has promised ‘to raise a question’ about changes to our Ambassador [Vyacheslav Kochemassov] for transmittal to Gorbachev. Honecker warned him: [If you do it] you will become my enemy.

However, Krenz seems to have taken the step. What is about to happen?28

A few days after the 40th anniversary ‘celebrations’, 70,000 protestors – squeezed shoulder to shoulder – converged in the centre of Leipzig demanding change. According to some in the SED, Honecker had made no secret of his willingness to fire on protestors if called upon to do so – a